ReviiEwCo
More Reviews. More Trust. More Business

FREE GUIDE FOR HOME SERVICE OWNERS

GOOGLE REVIEW RULES 2026

What Google and the FTC allow, what changed in April 2026, and the 8 questions to ask before you pay anyone to help with reviews.

By Rob Warfield, founder of ReviiewCo · Greenville, SC · October 2026
reviiewco.com · 864-528-1909

PROTECT YOUR PROFILE

YOUR GOOGLE PROFILE BELONGS TO YOUR BUSINESS. PROTECT IT.

This is where contractors get burned, usually because a vendor told them something was fine. Here's what's allowed, what isn't, and what changed this year, in plain English.

DO

- ✓ Ask every customer, the same way, whether you think they're happy or not.
- ✓ Make it easy: one text or email with a direct link to your review box.
- ✓ Give unhappy customers an easy way to reach you directly, too.
- ✓ Reply to reviews, good and bad, in your business's name.

DON'T

- × Offer incentives "such as payment, discounts, free goods and/or services" for a review. (Google)
- × "Discourage or prohibit negative reviews, or selectively solicit positive reviews." (Google) Sending unhappy customers to a private form instead of Google is exactly this.
- × Pressure customers to review while you're on site, or post reviews from staff or family.
- × Write fake reviews, AI or not, or use "unfounded or groundless legal threats" to get one removed. (FTC)
- × Ask customers to mention a tech by name, a service or certain words, or have staff collect reviews that name an employee. (Google, 2026)
- × Give your techs or office a review quota or a target number of reviews to bring in. (Google, 2026)

WHAT CHANGED IN 2026

Google tightened its Rating Manipulation policy in April 2026. Businesses must not ask staff to bring in a certain number of reviews, or to collect reviews that include specific content, including content that names a staff member.

> **What that means for you:** per-tech review contests and "please mention Mike" requests are out. Reward your crew for good work you measure yourself, not for reviews. If a customer names your tech on their own, that's fine.

The FTC's rule on consumer reviews took effect in October 2024. It also bars incentives "conditioned on the writing of consumer reviews expressing a particular sentiment," and insider reviews that hide the writer's connection to the business.

The simple version: ask every customer the same way, don't tell them what to write, give nothing for the review, never write one yourself, and never threaten anyone over one.

WHAT GETTING HELP COSTS (OCTOBER 2026)

Option	Who does the work	Typical monthly cost
Review feature built into your job software	You	$0–$99 extra
Self-serve review app	You	$45–$125
Done-for-you review service	They do	$297–$400
Sales-led review platform	Mostly you	≈ $300–$800 (estimate; often 12-month contracts)
Marketing agency bundle	They do (reviews are one line item)	$1,750 and up

From prices published on company websites in October 2026. Sales-led platforms don't publish prices, so that range is an estimate from third-party pricing guides. Prices change.

8 QUESTIONS TO ASK ANYONE BEFORE YOU SIGN

1. **Is the price published, and what isn't included?** Setup fees, per-text charges, extra locations and users. Get the total in writing.
2. **Is there a contract, and how do I leave?** How long, does it renew on its own, how many days' notice? Calendar the notice date the day you sign.
3. **Who actually does the work?** "Automated" often means you set it up and check on it. Ask what your part is each week, in minutes.
4. **Do you ask every customer, or only the happy ones?** Filtering is what Google's policy prohibits. It's your profile at risk.
5. **What about customers I've already served?** Is working your old list included, how is it paced, and who cleans up the list?
6. **Who replies to reviews, and how fast?** A suggested reply nobody posts doesn't help you.

7. **What happens if it doesn't work?** Get anything promised in writing, including what counts and by when.
8. **What happens to my reviews if I leave?** The right answer: they stay on your Google profile, because it belongs to your business.

SOURCES

- Google Maps user contributed content policy, Prohibited & restricted content: support.google.com/contributionpolicy/answer/7400114
- PPC Land, Google tightens Maps review policy, staff names and quotas now banned (Apr 2026): ppc.land
- FTC, Final rule banning fake reviews and testimonials (Aug 2024): ftc.gov
- Google Business Profile Help, How to improve your local ranking: support.google.com/business/answer/7091
- Full guide: reviiewco.com/review-management-for-contractors

DO IT YOURSELF, OR HAND IT OFF

THAT'S THE WHOLE PLAYBOOK.

Everything above works, and you can do every bit of it yourself. Most owners we talk to don't have the time, because they're out doing the work. That's exactly what ReviiewCo is for.

Do it yourself

- Ask every customer, every job, the same way
- Work your old customer list in steady batches
- Reply to every review within a few days
- Keep it going when the schedule gets busy

Or we do it for you

- A friendly text after every job, plus up to two reminders
- Your past-customer list worked for you
- A reply to every review, in your voice
- Missed-Call-Text Back included

$297/month. No contract. No setup fee.

Guarantee: at least 10 new Google reviews in 30 days when you send us a list of 300+ past customers, or every dollar back. The 30 days start once we have your list and access to your Google profile.

Talk it through with Rob (30 min, no pressure)
reviiewco.com/book

Get started
reviiewco.com/start

Call or text, answered 24/7
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General information, not legal advice. Example names, reviews and texts are illustrations, not real customers.